Institution: Royal Ontario Museum
Registration Number: 923.13.45
Beazley Archive Number: 16127
Fabric: Athenian, red-figure
Shape: Chous (small wine-jug)
Attribution: No attribution available
Date: c. 425-400 BCE
Dimensions: N/A
Provenance: Gift of the Members of the Royal Ontario Museum

Fabric, Technique, Shape & Condition Miniature Attic red-figure chous with a trefoil mouth. Plump-rounded body and a smooth profile are characteristic of the shape.[1] Figures rendered in reserved clay against a black-glazed ground. Black glaze shows chipping, but no significant losses are seen on the decorative areas of the vessel. Shape is intact, with minor chipping on the spout visible.

Iconography The vessel carries a single figural scene on its body, as is conventional for choes of this type. A boy crouches on one knee, playing with a ball (Fig. 1). He wears a fillet-wreath on his head. The wearing of wreaths by children depicted on choes reflects the custom of crowning children with flowers during the Anthesteria spring festival.[2] A string of four pendant amulets adorns his upper body. The wearing of amulets in the form of beads or pendants strung on a cord is well-attested in the iconography of choes from the 5th century BCE and serve as a mark that the child is under ritual protection.[3] To his left, a chous rests on the ground, and to his right, there is a cluster of grapes. The inclusion of the vessel within its own decoration creates a self-referential motif characteristic of the genre, while the grapes serve as a conventional allusion to wine and the Dionysiac context of the Anthesteria and particularly the Choes festival. Balls are among the common range of toys documented across the corpus of existing choes, which collectively constitute the best surviving record of children's activities at specific ages in ancient Athens.[4]

Fig. 1. *Chous (Jug) Showing a Boy Playing*, Greek, Attic, ca. 425–400 BCE. Wheel-thrown earthenware; red-figure. Gift of the Members of the Royal Ontario Museum. Royal Ontario Museum, Toronto, 923.13.45.

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[1] Classical Art Research Centre, University of Oxford. "Pouring Vessels." Introduction to Greek Pottery: Shapes. Accessed April 3. https://www.carc.ox.ac.uk/carc/resources/Introduction-to-Greek-Pottery/Shapes/Pouring-vessels.
[2] Neils, Jenifer, John Howard Oakley, Katherine Hart, Lesley A Beaumont, and Hood Museum of Art. *Coming of Age in Ancient Greece : Images of Childhood from the Classical Past*. Yale University Press in association with Hood Museum of Art, Dartmouth College, Hanover, New Hampshire, 2003.
[3] Muskett, "Rites of Passage for Young Children in Mycenaean Greece," *Childhood in the Past* 1 (2008): 44–45.
[4] Ibid.

Attribution & Dating No individual attribution is possible for this vessel. Miniature choes decorated with children at play were produced in large numbers toward the end of the 5th century BCE and were likely given as presents to children between the ages of 3-4, possibly for their first taste of wine at the Choes festival. Over a thousand examples are extant, with some retrieved from children's graves.[5] A date of approximately 425-400 BCE is supported by the style of the figural work and the vessel's place within the broader corpus. The miniature scale and child subject are consistent with both festival and funerary use of the shape. If a child died before reaching the age to participate in the Anthesteria, a chous would form part of the grave offerings, either as a personal possession or as a reference to the festival the child did not survive to attend.[6]

[5] Neils, Jenifer, John Howard Oakley, Katherine Hart, Lesley A Beaumont, and Hood Museum of Art. *Coming of Age in Ancient Greece : Images of Childhood from the Classical Past*. Yale University Press in association with Hood Museum of Art, Dartmouth College, Hanover, New Hampshire, 2003.

[6] Muskett, "Rites of Passage for Young Children in Mycenaean Greece," *Childhood in the Past* 1 (2008): 44–45.

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Royal Ontario Museum. "Attic Red-Figure Chous (Jug) Showing a Boy Playing." Acc. no. 923.13.45. Ca. 425–400 BCE. Gift of the Members of the Royal Ontario Museum. Accessed April 3, 2026. https://collections.rom.on.ca/objects/324390.

Muskett, "Rites of Passage for Young Children in Mycenaean Greece," *Childhood in the Past* 1 (2008): 44–45.

Neils, Jenifer, John Howard Oakley, Katherine Hart, Lesley A Beaumont, and Hood Museum of Art. *Coming of Age in Ancient Greece : Images of Childhood from the Classical Past*. Yale University Press in association with Hood Museum of Art, Dartmouth College, Hanover, New Hampshire, 2003.